

Historical Background of Greek Mythology

At last I was able to realize the dream of my whole life, and to visit at my leisure the scene of those events which had such an intense interest for me, and the country of the heroes whose adventures had delighted and comforted my childhood.

—HEINRICH SCHLIEMANN

AS WE HAVE ALREADY seen, the historical dimension is a prominent feature of Greek legend or saga, and an outline of the historical background will be helpful for a fuller understanding.¹ Our knowledge of the early history of Greece and the Aegean is constantly changing, thanks to the fresh discoveries of archaeologists and other scholars. Consequently, our view of Greek religion and mythology has been (and will continue to be) modified by new knowledge, not least in the area of legends that cluster around the sagas of Mycenae and Troy.

The foundations of modern archaeological work in the Mycenaean world were laid by the brilliant pioneer Heinrich **Schliemann** (1822–1890), who, because of his love of Greek antiquity in general and Homer in particular, was inspired by a faith in the ultimate historical authenticity of Greek legend. Although Schliemann's character and achievement have come under vehement attack, it is impossible to deny him pride of place.² In the 1870s, he went to Troy, Mycenae, and Tiryns and confirmed the reality of the wealth, grandeur, and power of the cities, kings, and heroes of Minoan-Mycenaean saga. Sir Arthur **Evans** followed at the turn of the century, unearthing the splendid and grand complex of the palace of Minos at Cnossus in Crete. A whole new world had been opened up.

For a long time, it was believed that Greece had not been inhabited before the Neolithic period. But we know today that the country was settled in Paleolithic times (before 70,000 B.C.). With the present state of excavation and study, our knowledge of this early period remains tentative. Evidence for the Neolithic period (ca. 6000–3000 B.C.) is more abundant. Archaeology has revealed settled agricultural communities (i.e., outlines of houses, pottery, tools, and graves). It is conjectured that the Neolithic inhabitants came from the east and the north. For our purposes, it is noteworthy that evidence of religion seems



apparent; particularly significant are little female idols, their sexuality exaggerated by the depiction of swollen bellies, buttocks, and full breasts. Male figures (some ithyphallic) also are found, although in far fewer numbers. Was a fertility mother-goddess worshiped in this early period and perhaps already associated with a male consort? The interpretation of prehistoric icons for an understanding of the worship of gods and goddesses in patriarchal and matriarchal societies has become a subject of intense scrutiny.³

The Bronze Age

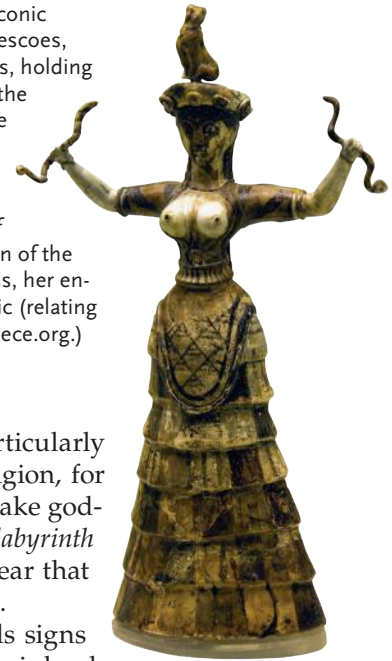
The Stone Age gave way to the Bronze Age in Greece, Crete, and the Islands with a migration from the east (the movement was from Asia Minor across the Aegean to the southern Peloponnesus and up into Greece). These invaders were responsible for building the great Minoan civilization of Crete. The Bronze Age is divided into three major periods: Early, Middle, and Late; these periods are also labeled according to geographical areas. Thus, the Bronze Age in Crete is designated as Minoan (from the tradition of King Minos); for the Islands the term is Cycladic (the Cyclades are the islands that encircle Delos); in Greece it is called Helladic (Hellas is the Greek name for the country). The Late Bronze Age on the mainland (i.e., the late Helladic period) is also identified as the Mycenaean Age, from the citadel of power (Mycenae) dominant in Greece during this period. The chronology with the terminology is as follows:⁴

3000–2000 B.C.	Early Bronze Age	Early Minoan Early Cycladic Early Helladic
2000–1600 B.C.	Middle Bronze Age	Middle Minoan Middle Cycladic Middle Helladic
1600–1100 B.C.	Late Bronze Age	Late Minoan Late Cycladic Late Helladic; also the Mycenaean Age

Minoan Civilization

The Minoan civilization grew to maturity in the Middle Bronze Age and reached its pinnacle of greatness in the following period (1600–1400 B.C.). The palace at Cnossus was particularly splendid (although another at Phaestus is impressive, too). The excavations confirm the tradition (as interpreted later, for example, by Thucydides 1.8.2) that Cnossus was the capital of a great thalassocracy (sea-power) and that Minoan power extended over the islands of the Aegean and even the mainland of Greece. The complex plan of the palace at Cnossus suggests the historical basis for the legend of the labyrinth and the slaying of the Minotaur by Theseus. Tribute was in all probability exacted from her allies or her subjects: Cnossus could have won temporary control over Athens, and the monarchy there could have been forced to pay tribute for a time; but subsequently, Athens would have won freedom from Cretan domination. The fact that Cnossus had no walls (unlike the fortress citadels of Hellas) indicates that its confident security depended on ships and the sea. The sophistication of Minoan

Snake Goddess from the Palace at Cnossos. Glazed earthenware figure (faience), ca. 1600 B.C., discovered by Sir Arthur Evans in 1903, now in the Archaeological Museum of Heraklion on Crete. It is representative of so many such figures unearthed at Minoan sites and has become iconic for much of Minoan culture. The statuette depicts a female, like those seen in Minoan frescoes, wearing an elaborate headdress and flounced skirt with open bodice and exposed breasts, holding a pair of snakes. In similar figurines, the snakes curl up the arms and around the ears of the figure. These statuettes have been used to support the still widely held theory that before the coming of the Greeks, the Minoans and early inhabitants of the Greek mainland worshiped a Great Mother Goddess. Since Linear A has yet to be deciphered, the interpretation of the meaning and function of these and other Minoan archaeological remains is elusive without any documentation. The theory that this is a representation of the Earth Mother Goddess herself (or one of her priestesses) is based on the proliferation of the figure, the presumed religious connotations of her ritual posture, her elaborate headdress, her enhanced attributes of fertility (i.e., full breasts and wide hips), and the image of the chthonic (relating to the earth) serpents. (Used with kind permission of Thomás Sakoulas and Ancient-Greece.org.)



art and architecture implies much about the civilization, but more particularly the painting and the artifacts reflect a highly developed sense of religion, for example, the importance of the bull in ritual, the dominant role of a snake goddess, and the sacred significance of the double ax (*labrys*).⁵ The word *labyrinth* may have originally meant “home of the double ax.” It seems fairly clear that the worship of a fertility mother-goddess was basic in Minoan religion.

By about 1400 B.C., Cretan power was eclipsed (archaeology reveals signs of fire and destruction), and the focus of civilization shifted to the mainland of Greece. Did the mainland Greeks overthrow Cnossos and usurp the Minoan thalassocracy, with the Athenians playing a significant role? Was an earthquake solely responsible for the eclipse of this island power? Theories abound, but there is no general agreement except insofar as scholars may be divided into two groups: those who stress the dominant influence of the Minoans on the mainland civilization and refuse to attribute the downfall of Crete to a Mycenaean invasion, as against those who argue for Mycenaean (Greek) encroachment and eventual control of the island. We incline to the latter view.

Excavations on the island of **Thera** (modern Santorini, about 70 miles northwest of Crete) have unearthed exciting new finds, among them interesting frescoes, and have indicated clear signs of destruction by earthquakes in the Minoan-Mycenaean period which may be dated ca. 1600 B.C. It had been conjectured that these same earthquakes were responsible for the disintegration of power on the island of Crete, but they now appear to have occurred earlier. At any rate, archaeologists have turned to the mythical tale about Atlantis (recorded by Plato in his *Critias* and *Timaeus*), a great island culture that vanished into the sea; conflict between Atlantis and Attica for control of the sea had broken out when earthquake and flood caused the astonishing disappearance of Atlantis. Does this Platonic legend reflect in any way the actual destruction of Thera, or of Crete itself, and the subsequent encroachment of Mycenaean power?⁶ Again no certain answer is forthcoming.

The Mycenaean Age

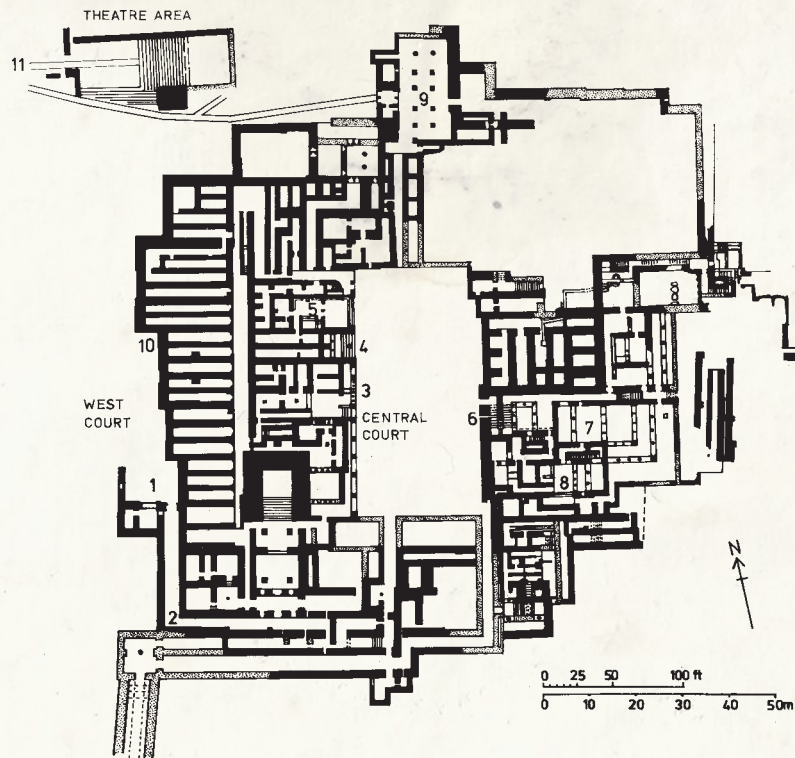
On the mainland of Greece, the Middle Bronze Age (or Middle Helladic period) was ushered in by an invasion from the north and possibly the east. These Indo-Europeans are the first Greeks (i.e., they spoke the Greek language) to enter the peninsula, and they brought with them the worship of a supreme god of the sky,

The Palace at Cnossus

In the *Odyssey*, Odysseus, disguised as a Cretan prince, dissembles about the many cities of his professed homeland, Crete, and says that "among them was Cnossus, a great city, and there Minos, friend of almighty Zeus, ruled for nine years" (*Odyssey* 19.179–180). In 1899, Sir Arthur Evans began his excavations at Cnossus and uncovered a prehistoric civilization previously known only through myth and tradition. Because of the association of the legendary King Minos with Crete (see pp. 593, 600–603), Evans called the civilization that he unearthed "Minoan." The excavations revealed the presence of a prosperous and sophisticated culture on

Diagram of Palace at Cnossus.

This plan of the palace is based on Sir Arthur Evans's original, complex reconstruction of the site. Subsequent archaeologists have argued for modifications. (GRAHAM, JAMES WALTER; *THE PALACES OF CRETE* © 1962 Princeton University Press, 1969 revised edition, 1990 renewed PUP Reprinted by permission of Princeton University Press)



The Palace at Knossos.

- | | | |
|------------------------------|---------------------------|---------------------------------|
| 1 West Porch | 5 Throne Room | 9 Pillar Hall |
| 2 Corridor of the Procession | 6 Grand Staircase | 10 Store-rooms |
| 3 Palace Shrine | 7 Hall of the Double Axes | 11 Royal Road, to Little Palace |
| 4 Stepped porch | 8 'Queen's Megaron' | |

Crete during the Bronze Age and confirmed the tradition of the dominant position of Cnossus. According to Evans, at the center of Minoan civilization was the palace, which was organized around a large, central court surrounded by storerooms, workshops, and living spaces. The palace at Cnossus was begun around 1700 B.C. and grew over the course of many years in a seemingly haphazard fashion, as space was needed. As a result, it is tempting to see in the mazelike complexity of the palace's layout and the ubiquitous bull motif a historical reality behind the legend of the Minotaur in the labyrinth and its link with Theseus.



North Entrance Passage, Cnossus. Archaeologists have found in this passage area some of the best-preserved frescoes in the debris at Cnossus. The bull's head, originally part of a more complete scene of a charging bull or a feat of "bull-grappling", is now in the Herakleion Museum. Evans believed the fresco decorated the wall behind the columns. The reconstructed fresco pictured here on site follows Evans conjecture, though doubt has been cast on the location of the original fresco.

named Zeus. Gradually, they created a civilization (usually called Mycenaean) that reached its culmination in the Late Helladic period (1600–1100 B.C.).⁷ They learned much from the Minoans; their painting, palaces, and pottery are strikingly similar, but there are some significant differences. Schliemann was the first to excavate at **Mycenae** (in 1876), the kingdom of the mythological family of Atreus, corroborating the appropriateness of the Homeric epithet, “rich in gold.” **Cyclopean** walls (so huge and monumental that they were said to be built by the giant Cyclopes of myth) typically surround the complex palace of the king and the homes of the aristocracy; the entrance to Mycenae was particularly splendid, graced as it was with a relief on which two lions or lionesses flanking a column were sculptured—presumably the relief was of political and religious significance, perhaps the emblem of the royal family. A circle of **shaft graves** within the citadel, set off in ritual splendor, has revealed a hoard of treasures—masks of beaten gold placed on the faces of the corpses, exquisite jewelry, and beautifully decorated weapons. Larger (and later) **tholos tombs** (also typical of Mycenaean civilization elsewhere and confirming a belief in the afterlife), built like huge beehives into the sides of hills below the palace complex, were dramatically and erroneously identified by Schliemann as both the treasury of Atreus and the tomb of Clytemnestra.

Schliemann’s discoveries established the certainty of a link between the traditional tales of Greek saga, especially those contained in the Homeric poems, and the actual places named in the poems, for example, Mycenae. Archaeologists have proved that these places were prosperous centers during the Mycenaean Age, and the distinction must be appreciated between the legends of heroes associated with Mycenaean palaces (Agamemnon at Mycenae, Heracles at Tiryns, Oedipus at Thebes, and Nestor at Pylos, to name four such heroes) and the actual world revealed by archaeologists. Carl Blegen’s discovery (1939, 1952–1969) of the Mycenaean palace at **Pylos** settled once and for all the controversy over its site and established the plan of the palace, with its well-preserved **megaron** (i.e., central room with an open hearth); and his conclusion that this is the palace of the family of Nestor seems inevitable. It is difficult to imagine to what families, other than those of the legends, these citadels could have belonged. Yet, of course, we must be wary of a naive belief in the details of the poetic tradition.

In religion, there were important differences between the Minoans and the Mycenaeans. The northern invaders of 2000 B.C. worshiped in particular a sky-god, Zeus, and in general their religious attitudes were not unlike those mirrored in the world of Homer’s celestial Olympians. How different from the spiritual atmosphere of the Minoans dominated by the conception of a fertility mother-goddess, with or without a male counterpart! At any rate, Greek mythology seems to accommodate and reflect the union of these two cultures, as we shall see in Chapter 3.

Linear B

Clay tablets inscribed with writing have been found on the mainland (an especially rich hoard was found at Pylos, which helped immeasurably in their decipherment). These tablets were baked hard in the conflagrations that destroyed these Mycenaean fortresses when they fell before the onslaught of the invaders.⁸ The key to deciphering the Linear B tablets was discovered in 1952 by Michael Ventris, who was killed in 1956 in an accident. His friend and collaborator, John Chadwick, has written for the layperson a fascinating account of their painstaking and exciting work on the tablets, one of the most significant scholastic and linguistic detective



Reconstruction of the Megaron at Pylos, by Piet de Jong; watercolor, originally from the Archaeological Museum in Chora, now in the Ephoreia of Olympia. Before modern color photography and computer-generated imagery became a commonplace tool for the archaeologist, Piet de Jong was one of the most prolific of archaeology illustrators, and his vision of the reconstruction of Minoan, Mycenaean, and later Greek spaces and art has influenced subsequent generations in terms of how they reimagine these lost worlds. He worked with some of the most famous names in the early days of archaeology, including Carl Blegen (see p. 44), who discovered and excavated the site of the palace of Nestor at Pylos. The megaron is a feature of Mycenaean architecture and is not to be found in Minoan palaces. The floor of the megaron with its central hearth is one of the best preserved of its type. The reconstruction here, except for the details of the floor and the hearth itself, is conjectural; the position of the throne (along the back wall) is based on archaeological evidence. The painted patterns on the hearth, such as tongues of flame, and the linear designs of various colors, set out in squares upon the floor, are still visible today. (Watercolor by Piet de Jong. Digitally edited by Craig Mauzy. Courtesy of the Department of Classics, University of Cincinnati.)



Closer Look

stories of this or any other age.⁹ It was, however, Emmett L. Bennett Jr. who was the founding father of the study of Mycenaean scripts, and his preliminary work on the Linear B tablets contributed greatly to their final decipherment by Ventris. While working on his PhD (completed in 1947) at the University of Cincinnati with Carl Blegen, who had unearthed hundreds of Linear B tablets in his excavation of Pylos, Bennett was given the golden opportunity to undertake his invaluable, pioneering work. Important for our study is the finding of the names of familiar deities of classical Greece: Zeus and Hera (listed as a pair), Poseidon, Hermes, Athena, Artemis, Eileithyia (Eleuthia in the tablets), and the name of the god Dionysus (a truly startling discovery, since it had usually been assumed that the worship of Dionysus did not come to Greece until after the Mycenaean age); also identified is an early form of the word *paean*, which was later applied as a title or epithet for Apollo. Similarly, Enualios appears, a name identified in classical times with Ares. The word *potnia* (mistress or lady) is frequent, and thus support is added to the theory that the Mycenaeans as well as the Minoans worshiped a goddess of the mother-fertility type and that the concept of chthonian (i.e., of the earth) deities

that this implies was merged with that of the Olympians. The gods are listed in the tablets as the recipients of offerings (i.e., of animals, olive oil, wheat, wine, and honey), which suggests ritual sacrifice and ceremonial banquets.

Linear B tablets have been found in some ten excavations in Mycenaean Greece and Crete. In 1993–1995, a large archive of tablets (over 259) was unearthed in Thebes. Those translated thus far confirm that in the thirteenth century B.C. Thebes controlled a powerful and rich kingdom with an impressive network of relationships. Such was the importance of the place founded by Cadmus and where Dionysus was born, with its many legends including those about the family of Oedipus. Cadmus is actually named by a Mycenaean king as one of that monarch's predecessors (probably in the fifteenth century) in a letter written in Hittite to the Great King of the Hittites. The catalogue of the ships in Book 2 of Homer's *Iliad* is historical in the prominent place given to Boeotia, from whose harbor at Aulis the Mycenaean expedition set sail against Troy.

Troy and the Trojan War

Frank Calvert, an amateur archaeologist who had lived for some time in the area of the Dardanelles, was convinced that Hisarlik was the site of Troy. He undertook a preliminary investigation (1863–1868) but did not have the finances to continue. The wealthy Heinrich Schliemann, convinced by Calvert's work and inspired by Homer's *Iliad*, proceeded with a more thorough excavation (1870–1873 and 1879–1890), accompanied by the architect Wilhelm Dörpfeld, who, after Schliemann's death, continued his mission (1882–1890). Carl Blegen was the next archaeologist to provide a significant reexamination of the site, from 1932 to 1938; after Blegen's, excavations have been renewed since 1988 by a team of archaeologists led by Manfred Korfmann from the University of Tübingen (Germany) and C. Brian Rose, who like Blegen before him is from the University of Cincinnati.¹⁰

Troy I–VI

There were nine settlements on the site of Troy, situated at the hill of Hisarlik. **Troy I** was settled in the Early Bronze Age (ca. 2920–2450 B.C.), and there continued to be successive settlements on the site for a long period of history. It was an important city in the historical Greek period (Troy VIII, Ilion, ca. 700–85 B.C.). The Romans restored the city on a large scale in the first century A.D. (Troy IX, Ilium, 85 B.C.–ca. A.D. 500); the imperial family of Augustus Caesar honored the city as the home of their ancestor Aeneas. It existed in the time of Constantine the Great (in the fourth century) but fell into disuse in the sixth century. Because of Homer and the renowned legend of the Trojan War, which the ancients accepted as historical fact, Troy became a revered site of Greek honor and glory.

Of the seven major settlements in the Minoan-Mycenaean period (Troy I–VII), **Troy II** (ca. 2600–2450 B.C., the citadel contemporary with the Late Troy I settlement) is particularly interesting because of treasure Schliemann claimed to have found at that level and his inaccurate assumption that he had found the city of Priam and the Trojan War. A picture that has become famous shows Schliemann's wife Sophia decked out in some of the jewelry from this treasure (called "The Gold of Troy" or "Priam's Treasure"), which Schliemann gave to the Berlin Museum. It disappeared during World War II, and not until the 1990s did the world learn that it resided in the Pushkin Museum in Moscow. When the Red Army overran Berlin at the end of

World War II, it shipped the valuable treasure off to Russia.¹¹ **Troy III–V** belong to the Early and Middle Bronze Ages (the period ca. 2450–1700 B.C.). **Troy VI** (Troia or Ilios, ca. 1700–1250 B.C., Middle-Late Bronze Age) was identified by Dörpfeld as the city of the Trojan War. The collapse of Troy VI is dated around 1250 B.C. by the new excavators, who believe that the final building phase was ended by a severe earthquake. The fortification walls of Troy VI are particularly impressive, and Dörpfeld identified this settlement as the great city of King Priam, besieged and taken by the Greeks. According to Blegen, however, Troy VI was devastated by an earthquake, but it was the next city, **Troy VII (Troy VIIa to be exact)**, that was the scene of the Trojan War, since for Blegen the evidence seems to provide signs of a siege and fire, indicative of the Trojan War: burnt debris and human skeletal remains, amid signs of devastation, wrought by invaders. For him the fall of Troy VIIa (not Troy VI) occurred around 1250. The new excavators date Troy VII at about 1250–1040 B.C., Late Bronze Age–Early Iron Age, its first phase VIIa ending around 1150 B.C. There is a continuity of culture between Troy VI and Troy VIIa; the ruins of houses and citadel walls were reused for repairs; buildings are much smaller, more cramped, and clearly arranged; the style of pottery remains Mycenaean; and the population and number of storage vessels are increased. All signs of a city under siege? After all, both Troy VI and Troy VIIa could be the city of Priam in two different phases. Blegen may, after all, be right, but of course much is in great dispute. Thus far, at any rate, Korfmann's conclusions seem to support Blegen's thesis.

Troy VI–VIIa: The City of Priam

The conclusion seems inevitable that the excavated Troy (whether Troy VI or Troy VIIa, or both) must be the city of Priam that fell to the Greeks; as for chronology, the approximate date of the conflict was 1250–1150 B.C., not too far from the traditionally accepted date of ca. 1184 B.C. for the fall of Troy.¹²

The citadel for Troy VI was newly constructed in eight successive stages, its size greater than any so far found in western Asia Minor, indicating its prestige and power. The fortifications consist of gently sloping walls of ashlar masonry, 4 to 5 meters thick and over 6 meters high, topped by a superstructure of mud-brick, with the inclusion of massive towers. The principal palaces on the summit no longer survive, but remains of large, impressive buildings have been found along the edge of the acropolis within the fortifications. There were several gates leading into the citadel, the principal one to the south, flanked by a tower.

The excavations that are in progress reveal that in Troy VI/VIIa the fortified upper citadel of the king was linked to a lower town by a defensive wall that surrounded it, making the size of the whole settlement approximately 200,000 square meters with a population of roughly 5,000–10,000 inhabitants. A ditch cut in the bedrock defined the outer limit of the inhabited city. This ditch was part of the defensive system, intended as an obstacle to delay attackers before they reached a wall, just north of it, “an arrow's throw” (according to Korfmann), about 90–120 meters from the ditch, on the side of the town.¹³ The fortification wall beyond the ditch was of stone, its upper section of mud-brick, enhanced by a wooden palisade with a sentry walk. (Where this wall of the lower town joined up to the northeast bastion of the citadel can be identified.) There are also clear indications of a causeway running through the palisade, in which a double wooden entrance gate was constructed, with a south gate offering controlled access to a major street through the lower town.

Astronomical Evidence in Homer for the Chronology of the Trojan War?

In Book 20 of the *Odyssey*, during a banquet of the suitors (at which Odysseus, disguised as a beggar, is present), the suitor Ageläus claims that Odysseus will never return and urges Telemachus to tell Penelope that she must marry one of them. Telemachus replies that he has told his mother to marry whomever she wishes. Homer describes the scene that follows and foreshadows the death of the suitors (345–358):

Thus spoke Telemachus. Then Pallas Athena instilled an unquenchable laughter in the suitors and befuddled their minds and they laughed with lips that seemed not their own. The meat that they were eating became sprinkled with blood, their eyes filled with tears and they thought that they were groaning laments. Among them, the seer Theoclymenus spoke: "Poor wretches, what is this evil you are suffering? Your heads, your faces, your knees, you are completely shrouded in night. Cries of wailing have been aroused. Spattered with blood are the walls and beautiful panels. The entrance and also the courtyard are full of ghosts going below in the dark to the gloom of the Underworld. The sun has been obliterated from the sky and an ill-omened darkness has fallen." These were his words but they all laughed at him happily.

The allegorist Heraclitus in the first century A.D. and Plutarch both interpreted the last sentence of Theoclymenus' prophecy ("The sun has been obliterated from the sky and an ill-omened darkness has fallen") as a poetic description of a total solar eclipse (when the moon blocks the sun briefly but completely). In 1926, C. Schoch (followed by P. V. Neugebauer) argued that Homer could be referring to a real and specific solar eclipse and identified it as the one that occurred on April 16, 1178 B.C., which would have been visible over the Ionian Islands. If this conclusion is correct, the fall of Troy would then have to be dated ca. 1188, since Odysseus traveled for ten years afterward, before he arrived home in Ithaca. Therefore, this astronomical evidence would provide yet another confirmation of the traditional and archaeological dates for Troy's fall in the period 1250–1150.

In subsequent years, the work of Schoch was evidently too hastily dismissed, and only recently has it found serious support as a result of the research of Marcelo O. Magnasco, head of the Laboratory of Mathematical Physics of the Rockefeller University in New York, and Constantino Baikouzis of the Observatorio Astronómico in La Plata, Argentina. They have scrupulously identified other astronomical indications in the *Odyssey* that may be linked to their argument, among them the presence of a new moon, a prerequisite for a total eclipse. They also readily admit the number of limitations and controversial issues inherent in their analysis, but they hope that other scholars may be inspired to pursue further research. The ingenuity and honesty of this painstaking astronomical scrutiny of Homer's text by two biophysicists of repute make their conclusions provocative.¹⁴

The main entrance to the upper citadel of Troy VI/VIIa was from the west, on the seaward side. A broad paved road, affording easy and dangerous access, led gently uphill to the fortress wall and ended at the largest gate in the fortress wall. (There was also a city gate here on the west side, very close, only about 80 meters, to the fortress gate.) Korfmann rightfully sees this topography reflected in the *Iliad*. This most vulnerable section of the fortress wall not only offered a clear view as far as Tenedos over the plain, which the attackers must have crossed,



Model of Troy VI, from Joachim Latacz, *Troy and Homer (Troia und Homer)*, translated by K. Windle and R. Ireland (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2004), p. 33, fig. 8. The model illustrates the results of the work of Manfred Korfmann (1952–2005) at Troy between 1988 and 2003. It shows the city that was possibly the immediate predecessor of Priam's Troy (Troy VII), destroyed by an earthquake in about 1250 B.C. and soon rebuilt. The citadel, with the royal palace and the houses of the elite Trojans, is at the top center, and below it is the lower town, inhabited by the ordinary citizens. The whole, with an extent of 200,000 square meters, was surrounded by a wall and a ditch. In the distance, about 8 kilometers away, lies the sea. (Christoph Haussner, Munich)

but also it was the only place where these Mycenaean warriors would have come close enough to be identified.

The recent excavations provide greater proof than ever that Troy VI/VIIa was a significant, palatial center, with its fortress citadel and inhabited lower town protected by a ditch and a wall—certainly compatible with the wealth and power of King Priam, celebrated in the heroic tradition.

The excavators have also found, just as Blegen did, indications within the lower town of a violent destruction for the end of Troy VIIa, for example, a hastily buried fifteen-year-old female and “a number of long-range weapons, such as arrowheads and spearheads, and over one hundred stone pellets, probably used for slings, which were piled in heaps. This may indicate defeat in battle because successful defenders usually clean up such piles, whereas victorious aggressors tend not to care about them.”

The Luwian Seal from Troy

Perhaps the most exciting find of all is a small round bronze seal (biconvex, i.e., convex on both sides) found in a one-room house. This first prehistoric inscription from Troy is to be dated in the second half of the twelfth century. Such seals

(which come in various types) are common and abundant because of the need to mark and identify one's own property with a stamp. Biconvex seals are a special type, usually with one side bearing the name of an official and the other the name of his wife. The language of the seal is Luwian, an Indo-European language like Hittite, of which it is a dialect. Traditional cuneiform Hittite (the official language of diplomacy) can be read today, but hieroglyphic Hittite, a complex pictographic script used for Luwian, has only recently been deciphered after prolonged research; complete decipherment has yet to be achieved. The Luwian language became a kind of demotic to high Hittite and was used widely among a multilingual population because it was more easily comprehensible. The text of the Luwian seal from Troy is poorly preserved. The personal names are illegible, but the title of the man is translated as *scribe* or *master-scribe*, and on the other side the word *wife*. Much (indeed, far too much) has been inferred from this one and only seal. That Luwian was a language used in Troy is credible, but there must have been many more languages in this international hub. That it was the major language of the Trojans is a much less likely conjecture. They may have spoken Greek. Perhaps in this case, too, Homer is right. Hector and Achilles could communicate with one another, and so could Paris with Helen. After all, the Trojans were descended from the same Indo-Europeans (identified as ancestors of the Mycenaean Greeks) who around 2000 B.C. came down into Greece from the north and also across the Dardenelles into Asia Minor. There is now real hope that more examples of writing may be found, perhaps in other houses in Troy VI/VIIa or in the tons of rubble that remain from Schliemann's excavations.

Hittite documents have emerged to offer vital new insights into the history of the Bronze Age. These texts "indicate strong connections between the Hittite kingdom and 'Wilusa,' which should probably be identified with Troy." Also, one of the texts (called the Alaksandu treaty) identifies among the deities of Wilusa a deity named Appaliunas, almost certainly the name for Apollo, the great god who took the side of the Trojans in the *Iliad*. The cult of Apollo is believed to be Anatolian or Cypriot in origin; after all, Homer does call him "Lycian-born." There are thousands of other such Hittite texts, which should be so enlightening, but sad to say they remain unread, waiting, waiting for willing scholars trained in the decipherment of cuneiform.

The Greek Armada Lands at Besika Bay

Other excavations under Korfmann's direction in the area of the Troad have unearthed further confirmation for the authenticity of Homeric geography and legend. Five miles southwest of Troy lies Besika Bay, where the original seashore at the time of the Trojan War has been identified; nearby, a cemetery containing about 200 graves surrounded by a single wall has been unearthed; the cremations and burials were accompanied by pottery and funeral offerings that are unmistakably Mycenaean and of the thirteenth century (the period of late Troy VI or Troy VIIa). It is difficult to resist the identification of this cemetery as that of the camp of the invading Greeks and Besika Bay, from which the island of Tenedos can be seen about 6 miles away, as the harbor where the Greeks anchored and encamped.

The Tomb of Achilles

Nearby is the headland of Yassi Tepe (formerly named Cape Troy) where there rises a great cone-shaped tumulus, Besik Tepe (now called Sivri Tepe), which most

certainly goes back to the Bronze Age and very probably is the great tumulus mentioned by Homer. It must also be the mound, believed in classical times to be the tomb of Achilles and visited by Xerxes and Alexander the Great. Alexander inspired by his love of the *Iliad*, saw himself and his comrade Hephaestion as a second Achilles and Patroclus. Another famous visitor to Troy was Xerxes, king of the Persians. On his march against Greece in 480 B.C., he was anxious to see the ancient and celebrated city of great King Priam. After he made a tour of the citadel and asked about the stirring legends of the Trojan War, he sacrificed oxen to Trojan Athena, and priests poured libations of wine to the heroes of old who had died there.

The Reality of the Trojan War

A detailed examination of abundant evidence confirms that Troy was a major center of commerce and trade in the second millennium. The city held the Hittite Empire at bay and remained relatively independent, eventually becoming a major contender in maritime traffic, with a stronghold on the vital area of the Black Sea, possibly even charging tolls for ships traveling through the Dardanelles. Serious economic reasons can easily be conjured up as legitimate causes for the Trojan War. After the Mycenaeans had conquered Cnossus, they aggressively assumed control of the Aegean and during the thirteenth century particularly, interfered frequently and significantly in the military and monetary affairs of western Asia Minor, even gaining for a time a foothold in Miletus. It was inevitable that they would finally move against Troy, a most pernicious rival.

In the epic cycle of saga, the great leaders of the Mycenaean kingdoms banded together to sail against Troy, and, even though the historical facts may be a matter of conjecture, the romance of this poetic legend has a reality too. Until it is disproven, we have every right to believe that there once were an Agamemnon and a Clytemnestra, a Hector and an Andromache and an Achilles, who lived and died, no matter how fictitious the details of the story that they inspired; and handsome Paris and beautiful Helen ran away together in the grip of Aphrodite, providing the inciting cause for a great war that has become immortal. The rigorously scientific, contemporary archaeologist and historian will settle for nothing less than written proof for the authenticity of the war and reality of its leaders. Perhaps the time is now here at last for the realization that all sorts of cumulative evidence (not only written records) from recent investigations in support of belief has become overwhelming.¹⁵

Carl Blegen, on the basis of much good evidence already acquired, wrote in 1963: "It can no longer be doubted, when one surveys the state of our knowledge today, that there really was an actual historical Trojan War in which a coalition of Achaeans, or Mycenaeans, under a king whose overlordship was recognized, fought against the people of Troy and their allies." His conviction gains further substantial support daily, and he would be gratified by the knowledge that Korfmann and many others today confidently use Homer as a secondary source of consequence, with intelligent caution of course, just the way he did.¹⁶

End of the Mycenaean Age

The destruction of the later phases of Troy VII (VIIb, to the beginning of the tenth century B.C.) marked the troublesome period of transition from the Late Bronze Age to the Age of Iron. The Greeks, we are to assume, returned from Troy

Timeline of Historical Events and Authors

7000–3000 B.C.	Neolithic Age	
3000–2000 B.C. 2000 B.C.	Early Greek Bronze age Greek-speaking peoples enter Greece	Oral Transmission of Myth and Legend
2000–1600 B.C.	Middle Bronze Age The flowering of Minoan civilization and the dominance of Cnossus	
1600–1100 B.C.	Late Bronze Age: The Mycenaean Age Mycenaean dominance over the Minoans	
1250–1150 B.C. 1184 B.C.	Period of the collapse of Troy VI and VII A traditional date for the fall of Troy	
1100–800 B.C.	Dark Age The Dorian invasion and the beginning of the Iron Age	
800–480 B.C. 546 B.C.	Archaic Period Cyrus the Great extends the Persian empire with the sack of Sardis and the defeat of Croesus, King of Lydia	Invention of the Greek Alphabet Homer (Iliad and Odyssey) Epic Cycle Hesiod (Theogony and Works and Days) Homeric Hymns Lyric Poets
753–509 B.C.	The founding of Rome by Romulus and the monarchy to the establishment of the Republic	
480–323 B.C. 480 B.C.	Classical Period The Persians sack Athens and destroy the temples on the Acropolis	Pindar (Victory Odes) Aeschylus, Sophocles, Euripides (Tragedy)
447–438 B.C.	Construction of the Parthenon as part of Pericles' building program	Herodotus (History) Thucydides (History) Aristophanes (Comedy) Plato (Philosophy) Aristotle (Philosophy)

323–31 B.C.	Hellenistic period	
323 B.C.	Death of Alexander the Great	<i>Callimachus (Hymns)</i> <i>Apollonius of Rhodes (Argonautica)</i>
1st Century B.C.	Late Roman Republic	<i>Lucretius (Epic)</i> <i>Catullus (Lyric)</i>
27 B.C.–A.D. 284	Early Roman Empire	<i>Vergil (Eclogues, Georgics, and Aeneid)</i>
27 B.C.–A.D. 14	Rule of Augustus, first Emperor of Rome	<i>Ovid (Metamorphoses, Fasti, etc.)</i> <i>Livy (Ab urbe condita)</i> <i>Seneca (Tragedy)</i> <i>Valerius Flaccus (Argonautica)</i> <i>Statius (Thebaid)</i> <i>Apollodorus (Library of Greek Mythology)</i> <i>Lucian (Mythological Satire)</i> <i>Apuleius (Metamorphoses or The Golden Ass)</i> <i>Pausanias (Description of Greece)</i> <i>Hyginus (Genealogies)</i>
A.D. 284–476	Later Empire to the Fall of Rome	
A.D. 313	Edict of Milan under Constantine establishes religious tolerance for Christianity	
A.D. 361–363	Julian the Apostate, the last non-Christian emperor, attempts to revive pagan worship	
A.D. 380	Theodosius establishes Christianity as the only legitimate religion and closes pagan sanctuaries	
A.D. 476	The fall of Rome	<i>Fulgentius (Mythologies)</i>

Homer

A cogent interpretation of the evidence offers answers to some of the many Homeric questions, amidst all the controversy. In the *Odyssey* (1. 350–351), when the bard Phemius sings of the disasters that the Achaeans suffered upon their return from Troy (so painful for Penelope to hear), Telemachus observes that the audience applauds most for the most recent tales. In a later book (8. 487–534), Demodocus at the request of Odysseus (whose identity is not known) sings readily about the wooden horse and the fall of Troy with such art that Odysseus is brought to tears. The recitation of oral poetry to the accompaniment of the lyre (phorminx) was part of the fabric of Mycenaean civilization. (A splendid fresco of a lyre player was found at Pylos.) The story of the Trojan War in all likelihood was first told simultaneously with the event or soon afterward, to be transmitted in a continuous tradition by generations of subsequent poets, with modifications, elaborations, and infinite creative variations. The Dorian invasion bringing an end to Mycenaean civilization (ca. 1100 B.C.) is now believed to have been less disruptive than previously thought. The poetic transmission, however, was in rigidly structured lines (the meter being dactylic hexameter), which was conducive to the retention of historical fact. A large body of repetitive formulaic material of varying types and lengths was crystallized (e.g., “swift-footed Achilles,” “rosy-fingered dawn,” or the set pattern of sacrificial ritual), to be drawn upon readily and to facilitate impromptu oral recitation before an audience. A highly skilled guild of professional rhapsodists (called Homeridae or Homerids) developed, and by the time of Homer oral epic had reached a pinnacle of artistic perfection. It was Homer who composed the *Iliad* and the *Odyssey* orally and was possibly the one who had the poems set down in writing in the eighth century B.C. Despite the centuries between the time of Homer and the Trojan War, the poet transmits much accurate historical detail that can come only from the period of the Trojan War. The most compelling example (among many others) is the catalogue of the ships (2. 494–759), which does not fit comfortably in its later context in the *Iliad* and describes an earlier political and geographical world that can only be Mycenaean. Credible is the tradition that a standard text of both poems was established in Athens at the time of the Pisistratid tyranny in the second half of the sixth century B.C.

in triumph. Yet not long after their return, the Mycenaean Age in Greece was brought to a violent end, perhaps precipitated by internal dissension. The widely held theory that the destruction was entirely the work of **Dorians** invading from the north and east has been questioned. Some historians not very convincingly associate the destruction of the Mycenaean kingdoms with the “sea peoples” mentioned in an Egyptian inscription put up by the pharaoh Rameses III in the twelfth century B.C., but there is still no certainty about the details of the end of the Bronze Age in Greece.

Darkness descends on the history of Greece, a darkness that is only gradually dispelled with the emergence of the two great Homeric epics, the *Iliad* and the *Odyssey*, in the eighth century B.C. The stories of the earlier period were kept alive by oral recitation, transmitted by bards like those described in the epics themselves. “Homer” almost certainly belongs to Asia Minor or one of the islands (e.g., Chios) off the coast. In the cities of this area in this period, we find that monarchy is the prevailing institution; significantly enough, the social and political

environment for the bard of this later age is not unlike that of his predecessors in the great days of Mycenae.

Most important for the appreciation of the cumulative nature of the growth of the legends is the realization that there were two major periods of creative impetus, one before the destruction of Mycenaean civilization and one after. The Homeric poems maintain the fact and fiction of the Bronze Age, but they also portray their own Age of Iron. To mention but one example, archaeology shows us that burial was prevalent in the Mycenaean Age, but in Homer cremation is common. The saga of the Argonauts reflects an interest in the Black Sea that is historical—but was this interest Mycenaean, or do the details belong to the later age of Greek colonization (ca. 800–600 B.C.)? The legend as we have it must be a composite product of both eras. The Theseus story blends, in splendid confusion, Minoan-Mycenaean elements with facts of the later historical period of monarchy in Athens.

The Homeric poems were eventually set down in writing; this was made possible by the invention of an alphabet in the eighth century B.C.¹⁷ The Greeks borrowed the symbols of the Phoenician script and used them to create a true alphabet, distinguishing by each sign individual vowels and consonants, unlike earlier scripts (such as Linear B) in which syllables are the only linguistic units. This stroke of genius, by the way, is typically Greek in its brilliant and inventive simplicity; surely no one of our countless debts to Greek civilization is more fundamental. Is the invention of the Greek alphabet and the setting down of the Homeric epics coincidental? Presumably, the dactylic hexameter of epic poetry cannot be reproduced in the clumsy symbols of Linear B. At any rate, when tradition tells us that the legendary Cadmus of Thebes taught the natives to write, we assume that he instructed them in Mycenaean Linear B rather than in the later Greek alphabet.

Select Bibliography

- Bittlestone, Robert, with James Diggle and John Underhill.** *Odysseus Unbound: The Search for Homer's Ithaca*. New York: Cambridge University Press, 2005.
- Bryce, Trevor.** *The Trojans and Their Neighbours*. New York: Routledge, 2005. In addition to a focus on Troy's neighbors, the involvement of Troy in the *Iliad* is also explored.
- Cambridge Ancient History.** 3d ed. Vols. 1 and 2. New York: Cambridge University Press, 1970–1975. The standard work of reference in English, with chapters by various authorities. These volumes cover the early history of the Aegean world and the Near East and Bronze Age Greece, which now needs to be updated.
- Castleden, Rodney.** *The Attack on Troy*. Barnsley, UK: Pen & Sword, 2006.
- . *Minoans: Life in Bronze Age Crete*. New York: Routledge, 1993. This book follows upon Castleden's previous work, *The Knossos Labyrinth* (1990), in which he postulates a new view about the palace.
- Chadwick, John.** *The Mycenaean World*. New York: Cambridge University Press, 1976.
- Dickinson, Oliver.** *The Aegean Bronze Age*. Cambridge World Archaeology. New York: Cambridge University Press, 1994.
- Drews, Robert.** *The End of the Bronze Age: Changes in Warfare and the Catastrophe ca. 1200 B.C.* Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1996.
- Ellis, Richard.** *Imagining Atlantis*. New York: Vintage Books, 1999. Countless and endless are the books about the legendary Atlantis. This one by Ellis is outstanding for its survey of the archaeological evidence and the many theories (fiction and film included) proposed by authors ranging from Plato to Arthur Conan Doyle.

- Fields, Nic.** *Troy c. 1700–1250 B.C.* New York: Osprey Publishing, 2004. A well-illustrated, up-to-date, and concise discussion.
- Fitton, J. Lesley.** *The Discovery of the Greek Bronze Age.* Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1996. An excellent survey of the excavations and their historical interpretation.
- Gerster, Georg.** *The Sites of Ancient Greece.* London: Phaidon Press, 2012. A beautiful tour of the Greek world using gorgeous aerial photography.
- Latacz, Joachim.** *Troy and Homer: Towards a Solution of an Old Mystery.* Translated by Kevin Windle and Rosh Ireland. New York: Oxford University Press, 2004. The most up-to-date survey of the continuing excavation, which includes analysis of the most recent important and exciting finds.
- Luce, J. V.** *Homer's Landscapes: Troy and Ithaca Revisited.* New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 1998. A gratifying study that restores one's faith in the maligned historicity of Homer. Luce shows the accuracy of Homer's geography of Troy and the Troad in the *Iliad* and convinces us that the modern islands of Lefkas, Itháki, Kephallonia, and Zante, off the Gulf of Corinth, correspond to the descriptions in the *Odyssey* for Doulichion, Ithaca, Samos (Samê), and Zakynthos. Although archaeology confirms Mycenaean evidence on the islands, the palace of Odysseus remains to be discovered.
- Mellersh, H. E.** *The Destruction of Knossos: The Rise and Fall of Minoan Crete.* New York: Weybright & Talley, 1970.
- Papadopoulos, John K.** *The Art of Antiquity: Piet de Jong and the Athenian Agora.* American School of Classical Studies. New York: David Brown Book Co., 2007. Includes a discussion and illustrations of de Jong's work for the Minoan and Mycenaean periods.
- Schofield, Louise.** *The Mycenaeans.* New York: Oxford University Press, 2007. Includes 100 illustrations.
- Sowerby, Robin.** *The Greeks and Their Culture.* 2d ed. New York: Routledge, 2009. A wide-ranging introductory survey of ancient Greek history, religion, social life, literature, and philosophy.
- Vidal-Naquet, Pierre.** *A Short History of Plato's Myth of Atlantis.* Exeter, UK: University of Exeter Press, 2007. A reexamination of the different uses made of the myth in different contexts and periods.
- Winkler, Martin M., ed.** *Troy: From Homer's "Iliad" to Film Epic.* Malden, MA: Blackwell, 2006. Provides an annotated list of films (including TV) on the Trojan War, with illustrations.
- Wood, Michael.** *In Search of the Trojan War*, new ed. Berkeley: University of California Press, 1996. Originally based on the BBC television series and now updated, this is a good survey. It now needs to be updated further, and the reader should consult Latacz (2004) for the most recent finds and interpretations.
- Ziolkowski, Theodore.** *Minos and the Moderns: Cretan Myth in Twentieth-Century Literature and Art.* New York: Oxford University Press, 2008.

Notes

1. Emily Vermeule, *Greece in the Bronze Age* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1964), offers a survey (now out of date) that contains important earlier bibliography. Vermeule regrettably ignores Homer as evidence; fortunately, however, many archaeologists today have returned to Homer cautiously with important results. See note 15 for Fitton's more recent survey.
2. Schliemann's life and career are the material for a bizarre and exciting success story. He amassed a fortune so that he could prove the validity of his convictions, which he

pursued with passion. Earlier biographies tend to be romantically sympathetic: Emil Ludwig, *Schliemann: The Story of a Gold-Seeker* (Boston: Little, Brown, 1931); Robert Payne, *The Gold of Troy* (New York: Funk and Wagnalls, 1959); Lynn and Gray Poole, *One Passion, Two Loves* (New York: Thomas Y. Crowell, 1966); and Irving Stone, *The Greek Treasure* (New York: Doubleday, 1975). More recently, Schliemann has been characterized as a liar and a fraud: David A. Traill, *Schliemann of Troy: Treasure and Deceit* (New York: St. Martin's Press, 1995). Less scholarly, but nevertheless critical and more balanced, is the biography by Caroline Moorehead: *Lost and Found: The 9,000 Treasures of Troy: Heinrich Schliemann and the Gold That Got Away* (New York: Viking Press, 1996 [1994]). Susan Heuck Allen, *Finding the Walls of Troy* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1999), another detractor, argues that Schliemann obscured his debts to the British archaeologist Frank Calvert for the identification and excavation of the mound of Hisarlik as the site of Troy.

3. See the bibliography for Iconography, Religion, and Feminist Interpretations in Chapter 1, p. 33.
4. The dates for these periods are serviceable. It is rash to insist on greater precision for this early period, for the evidence for it fluctuates daily. The chronology of the Bronze Age is a subject of passionate dispute. Thus, attempts at a more precise chronology with further subdivisions within the periods are not reproduced here. For a scholarly treatment, consult pertinent chapters and charts in *The Cambridge Ancient History*, 3d ed., vol. 2, pt. 1, *The Middle East and the Aegean Region 1800–1380 B.C.*, edited by I. E. S. Edwards, N. G. L. Hammond, and E. Sollberger (New York: Cambridge University Press, 1973); and pt. 2, *The Middle East and the Aegean Region c. 1380–1000 B.C.* (1975).
5. For a more detailed interpretation of the evidence in terms of Minoan-Mycenaean religion, see W. K. C. Guthrie, "The Religion and Mythology of the Greeks," in Edwards et al., eds., *The Cambridge Ancient History*, vol. 2, pt. 2, Chapter 40.
6. For a survey of the excavations at Thera, the relationship to Crete, and theories about Atlantis, see Christos G. Doulas, *Thera: Pompeii of the Ancient Aegean* (London: Thames & Hudson, 1983).
7. Some believe that a later wave of invaders (ca. 1600 B.C.) is to be specifically identified as the Achaeans in Homer; it is better to consider Achaeans as virtually an equivalent term for the Mycenaean Greeks.
8. Linear A tablets (Linear B is derived from the Linear A script), found on Crete, have not yet been deciphered; apparently Minoan Linear A is not Greek. Linear B tablets (written in an early form of Greek) have also been found at Cnossus, with provocative implications for historical reconstruction. Hostile criticism of Evans is offered by Leonard R. Palmer, *Mycenaeans and Minoans*, 2d ed. (New York: Knopf, 1965).
9. John Chadwick, *The Decipherment of Linear B*, 2d ed. (New York: Cambridge University Press, 1958).
10. Blegen's results have been published in a series of highly technical volumes. Like the reports of his excavations at Pylos, they are a monumental testimony to the scientific precision of modern archaeological procedures. Blegen has provided a survey of the excavations at Troy for the general reader: Carl W. Blegen, *Troy and the Trojans* (New York: Praeger, 1963). We are grateful to Manfred Korfmann, C. Brian Rose, and Getzel Cohen for information about the new excavations of Troy.
11. The official catalogue of the "Gold of Troy" exhibition at the Pushkin State Museum of Fine Arts, Moscow (with beautiful color illustrations), has been published: Vladimir Tolstikov and Mikhail Treister, *The Gold of Troy: Searching for Homer's Fabled City*. Translated from the Russian by Christina Sever and Mila Bonnicksen (New York: Harry N. Abrams, 1996).
12. Details and quotations about the excavations come from the *Newsletters of the Friends of Troy*, offered by the Institute for Mediterranean Studies in Cincinnati. This information has been updated, with the most recent material from Joachim Latacz, *Troy and Homer: Towards a Solution of an Old Mystery*. Translated by Kevin Windle and Rosh

Ireland (New York: Oxford University Press, 2004). Latacz, a friend and colleague of Manfred Korfmann (director of the excavations until his death in 2005), presents the most recent survey (the first edition, 2001, has been revised and expanded). Scholarly annual excavation reports appear in *Studia Troica* (Mainz, Germany: Verlag Philipp von Zabern), published in both German and English, which also includes interdisciplinary research concerning Troy.

13. A second ditch found over 100 meters south of and in front of the first ditch offered another, preliminary obstacle, perhaps against chariot attacks. It is unknown if this measure of redoubled security was backed by a wall.
14. Constantino Baikouzis and Marcelo O. Magnasco. "Is an Eclipse Described in the Odyssey?" *Proceedings of the National Academy of Science*, 105, no. 26 (July 2008), pp. 8823–8828.
15. J. Lesley Fitton, in her survey of Bronze Age archaeology, *The Discovery of the Greek Bronze Age* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1996), sensibly observes (p. 203): "It seems a sad decline to our modern recognition that the material remains of a pre-literate society, incompletely recovered, can properly be expected only to answer limited and impersonal questions." Nevertheless, she concludes (p. 197) that "Without writing, 'proof' [of the Trojan War] is well nigh unimaginable."
16. See Carl W. Blegen, *Troy and the Trojans* (New York: Praeger, 1963), p. 20.
17. The argument for connecting Homer with the invention of the alphabet has been cogently made by H. T. Wade-Gery, *The Poet of the Iliad* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 1952). See also Barry B. Powell, *Homer and the Origins of the Greek Alphabet* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 1991).

Myths of Creation

Now the whole of heaven (uranus)—or let us call it the universe (cosmos) or some other name that it would prefer—regarding it we must consider first that question underlying every investigation which must be sought at the outset. Has it always existed, with no origin from generation, or has it come into being, arising out of some beginning?

—PLATO, *Timaeus* 28b



THERE WERE MANY MYTHS about creation among the Greeks and Romans, and these myths have many parallels in other mythologies, such as Egyptian, Sumerian, Babylonian, and Hebraic. Homer (ca. 800 B.C.) has the Titans Oceanus and Tethys (identified later in this chapter) responsible for the origin of the gods (*Iliad* 14. 201) and reflects a primitive belief that the universe can be understood in terms of a simple geography. The world is a flat disc with hills, touched at its rim by the vast dome of the heavens. The deity Oceanus is the stream of ocean that encircles the earth (see figure on p. 619). But Homer does not by any means provide a complete account of genesis. Hesiod (ca. 700 B.C.), as far as we can tell, was the first to give literary expression to a systematic explanation of how the gods, the universe, and humankind came into being. At any rate his account, the earliest to survive, may be considered the classic Greek version. The genealogical scheme is presented in his *Theogony*, while his *Works and Days* adds significant details.

Hesiod

In the opening of the *Theogony*, Hesiod devotes many lines to the beauty and power of the **Muses**, with particular emphasis on their ability to inspire the infallible revelation of the poet. He lovingly describes their graceful dancing and exquisite singing to delight the gods on Olympus. This ardent invocation to the Muses is no mere artistic convention but rather the utterance of a prophetic visionary. Since the Muses are the daughters of Zeus, their revelation comes from the infallible knowledge